Subject and Object markers as pronominal clitics in Akan

1. Introduction

- Akan exhibits subject markers which are in complementary distribution with non-focused subject DPs:

(1) **ɔ-bo-o Kofi**
3SG-beat-PST Kofi[1]
'He beat Kofi.'

(2) **Ama bo-o Kofi**
Ama beat-PST Kofi
'Ama beat Kofi.'

(3) ***Ama ɔ-bo-o Kofi**
Ama 3SG-beat-PST Kofi

- ✓ One context where these subject markers cooccur with subject DPs is focused-subject constructions:

(4) **Kofi$_1$ na ɔ$_1$-bo-o no.**
K FOC 3SG-beat-PST 3SG
'KOFI beat him (not Ama).'

Goal

- We reanalyze the subject prefixes and object pronouns as pronominal clitics.
- These pronominal clitics are in complementary distribution with overt DPs; except in focus constructions.
- We argue that in focus constructions a resumptive pronoun matching the φ-features of the A-bar-moved DP is spelled out in the extraction site.

Eralier Accounts

- ✓ Earlier accounts about the status of Akan subject (pronominal) prefixes (see Table 2) (cf. Saah 1994, Osam 1994, Korsah 2017, Yip and Ahenkorah, 2023).

- ✓ Saah (1994, p. 90) and Osam (1994) treat prefixes such as **ɔ-** ((1)) as nominative pronouns. Osam believes that diachronically, they have shifted from agreement to pronouns (this is against cross-linguistics patterns (Givon, 1979)

- ✓ Several other studies that discuss focus construction in Akan refer to these forms as resumptive pronouns (RPs). (see e.g. Hatav & Essegbey, 2024; Marfo & Bodomo, 2005; Pfeil et al., 2015; Titov, 2019).

- Korsah (2017): Akan lacks subject pronouns; the morphemes are agreement markers.
  - Evidence: lack of coordination with DP; ATR phonology; optionality of ***ɛ-*** in local extraction
  - Timing of movement between phi-P and the operator marked DP ((5)).

[1] Abbreviations: 1, 2, 3=first/second/third person; AN/IN=animate/inanimate; C=complementizer; CORD= coordinator; DET=determiner; FOC=focus marker, PL=plural; POSS=possessive; PST=past tense marker; REFL= reflexive; SG=singular; TOP=topic marker

(5)

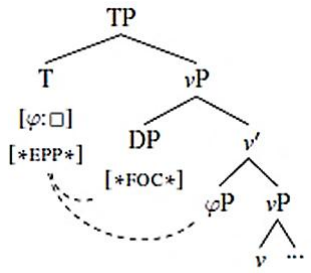


Table 1: Optionality of Agreement (Korsah, 2017)

Optionality of agreement		
Movement	Agree	Spell-out
(a) DP-to-spec, TP	✗	Default
(b) *phi*P-to-spec, TP	✓	Full *phi*-features

(6) **Kofi$_1$ na ɛ$_1$-bo-o Yaw**.
K FOC 3SG-beat-PST Y
'KOFI beat Yaw.'

- Yip and Ahenkorah (2023): treat **ɔ-** and **ɛ-** as pronouns.
  - **ɛ-** derived as spell-out of lower copy in movement chain via partial Copy Deletion
  - **ɔ-** as base-generated pronouns

The derivation of Akan non-agreeing RP *ɛ-* in

(7)

a. Baseline	(syntax)	$[_{TP}$	T $[_{vP}$ DP$_{[D, +pl, +anim, n, \sqrt{FRIEND}]}$ …]]
b. Subj. mvt.	(syntax)	$[_{TP}$ DP$[_{D, +pl, +anim, n, \sqrt{FRIEND}]}$	T $[_{vP}$ <DP$_{[D, +pl, +anim, n, \sqrt{FRIEND}]}$> …]]
c. Partial CD	(PF)	$[_{TP}$ DP$_{[D, +pl, +anim, n, \sqrt{FRIEND}]}$	T $[_{vP}$ <DP$_{[D, \sout{+pl, +anim, n, \sqrt{FRIEND}}]}$> …]]
d. VI	(PF)	$[_{TP}$ *n-nam-fo-nom no*	T $[_{vP}$ <ɛ> …]]

- ✓ These studies typically focus only on Akan subject prefixes (see column 3 of Table 2) and the object pronoun, but not the strong pronouns (column 2 of Table 2).
- ✓ Akan appears to have morpho-phonologically distinct sets of pronominals: strong pronouns, subject clitics, and object clitics.
- ✓ **ɛ-** in A-bar configuration is not morpho-syntactically derived.

Table 2: The pronominal inventory of Akan (Asante Twi)

	Strong Obj/Subj	**Subject Prefix (Clitic)**	**Object Pronoun**
1SG	me	me-	me
2SG	wo	wo-	wo
3SG animate	ɔno	*ɔ-*	no
3SG/3PL inanimate	ɛno	*ɛ-*	no
1PL	yɛn	*yɛ-*	yɛn
2PL	mo	mo-	mo
3PL animate	wɔn	wɔ-	wɔn

Roadmap: §2 Language and theoretical backgrounds §3 Against the agreement morphology analysis §4 Akan pronominal continuum §5 The default marker/non-agreeing RP approach to ɛ- and our phonological alternative §6 Proposed analysis (subject/object RPs; alternative Big DP) §7 Open questions §8 Conclusion

2. Language and Theoretical backgrounds

Following Cardinaletti & Starke (1999), pronominal systems cross-linguistically divide into three classes ranked by structural deficiency: clitic < weak < strong. Clitics lack the most structure; strong pronouns the least.

- ✓ Strong pronouns: peripheral positions (topic, focus, cleft, isolation); can be coordinated with a DP; always bear their own range-restriction (cannot be expletive or impersonal) etc.
- ✓ Weak pronouns: prosodic units with lexical word-stress; can be coordinated with a DP; must occupy a derived functional (specFP) position but cannot incorporate into a head; cannot appear in peripheral positions.
- ✓ Pronominal clitics: must incorporate into a functional head (X°-chain); cannot be coordinated; are consistently destressed and must be adjacent to their verbal host etc.

3. Removing Agreement Morphology Analysis

3.1. Complementary distribution with full subject DPs

- ➢ Unlike agreement markers that co-occur with full DPs in many languages, in Akan this co-occurrence is blocked.
- ✓ Akan construction such as ((8)), like ((3)) violates Condition B (Chomsky, 1981).

(8) **Kofi$_1$ *ɔ$_1$-bo-o no.**
K 3SG-beat-PST 3SG
'Kofi beat him/her.'

- ➢ Aside from clitics without doubled DPs as in (1), Akan subject clitics surface as resumptive pronouns (RPs) bound by their coreferential DPs only in Spec,FocP or Spec,TopP ((4)) (see our proposal in §5).

Baker and Kramer (2018) note that they "expect that pronominal subject clitics analyzed as Ds adjoined to T could sneak through… if (b) subjects front, but to a preverbal A-bar position like TopicP, giving [Subject$_i$ SM$_i$+T-V …] order, but where the subject crucially does not A-bind the SM to create a binding theory violation."

- ✓ Condition B is not violated in focus constructions because the antecedent is in Spec,FocP, outside the TP binding domain (Bošković 2016).

3.2. Referentiality

- ➢ Subject prefixes are referentially active and give rise to ambiguous interpretation ((9)b).

(9) a. **Kofi$_1$ na ɛ$_1$-bo-o Yaw**.
K FOC 3SG-beat-PST Y
'KOFI beat Yaw.' [unambiguous interpretation]

b. Kofi$_1$ na ɔ$_{1/2}$-bo-o no$_{1/2}$.
K FOC 3SG-beat-PST 3SG
'He beat KOFI / KOFI beat him.' [ambiguous interpretation]

- ✓ Under subject focus, ((9)b) would $[\![ɔ_1]\!]^g = g(1)$ and $[\![no_2]\!]^g = g(2)$ as opposed to, disjoint reference between **Kofi** and **ɔ**, under object focus.
- ✓ We argue that **ɛ-** is not a distinct morpheme but a reduced form of the RP which occurs in rapid speech within an informationally redundant context.

➢ Akan subject prefixes also serve as antecedents for anaphors in binding configurations as in ((10)).

(10) **Ɔ-bo-o neho**
3SG-beat-PST REFL
'He beat himself.'

➢ Akan subject prefixes behave atypically for agreement morphology.

- ✓ Referential properties of **ɔ-** seen thus far are not expected of pure agreement morphology.
- ✓ Unless Akan is treated as a null-subject language (NSL), a conclusion drawn by Korsah (2017).

Such a conclusion is not without challenges: Camacho (2013, p, 13–25) lists six properties associated with the Null Subject Parameter: null subjects, null expletives, free subject inversion, null resumptive pronouns, long wh-extraction of subjects, and the absence of that-trace effects. Akan either lacks these properties or a way to test them.

Free Subject Inversion

- ✓ Consistent NSLs like Spanish and Italian allow VS order in root declaratives, with the postverbal subject as the canonical new-information position ((13)). Akan lacks free subject inversion ((14)).

(11) a. Habló Marta. (Spanish)
spoke Marta
'Marta spoke.'

b. Mangia Gianni. (Italian)
eats Gianni
'Gianni eats.'

(12) Akan:
a. *Kasa-ai Kofi.
speak-PST Kofi
'Kofi spoke.'

b. **Kofi kasa-ai.**
Kofi speak-PST
'Kofi spoke.'

Embedded Subject and Control

- ✓ In a consistent NSL like Spanish, the subject of a finite embedded clause is a null pronoun (*pro*). With a quantified antecedent it can be a bound variable, whereas the overt pronoun cannot (the Overt Pronoun Constraint; Camacho 2013, p. 30) ((13)).
- ✓ Akan has no null/overt alternation for the subject prefix, so the constraint cannot apply. The prefix allows both the bound/coreferent and the disjoint reading ((14)), like an English pronoun.

(13) a. Todo estudiante$_i$ cree que *pro*$_i$ es inteligente. (Spanish)
every student thinks that is intelligent
'Every student$_i$ thinks that he$_i$ is intelligent.'

b. Todo estudiante$_i$ cree que él$_{*i/j}$ es inteligente.
every student thinks that he is intelligent
'Every student$_i$ thinks that he$_j$ is intelligent.'

(14) **a. Kofi$_i$ dwene sɛ ɔ$_{i/j}$-nim adeɛ.**
Kofi think C 3SG-know thing
'Kofi thinks that he is intelligent.'

b. [Sukuuni biara]$_i$ dwene sɛ ɔ$_{i/j}$-nim adeɛ.
student every think C 3SG-know thing
'Every student thinks that he is intelligent.'

- ✓ In partial NSLs such as BP, Finnish and Marathi, an embedded subject can be null only if controlled (Camacho 2013, p. 36).
- ✓ In Akan, with a control predicate like *decide* ((15)), the overt prefix receives an obligatory control reading.

(15) **Kofi$_i$ yɛɛ n-adwene sɛ ɔ$_{i/*j}$-bɛ-ba.**
Kofi made his-mind C he-will-come
'Kofi decided to come.'

Null Expletives

- ✓ Akan uses the third person singular inanimate as an obligatory overt expletive ((16)), so it has no null expletives.

(16) **a. ɛ-wɔ sɛ nokórɛ nó túmí dá adi.**
3SG-be COMP truth DEF able lie bare
'The truth has to come to light.'

b. *wɔ sɛ nokórɛ nó túmí dá adi.
be COMP truth DEF able lie bare
'The truth has to come to light.'

- ✓ Finnish allows null 1st/2nd person subjects alongside an overt expletive, and El Cibao Dominican Spanish has null thematic subjects with an optional overt expletive (Camacho, 2013).

- ✓ Akan prefix is overt in every person (Table 2) and cannot co-occur with a subject DP ((3)).

Additionally, preverbal DPs in Akan are in Spec,TP. On one view, preverbal subjects in NSLs are dislocated topics, with the subject position filled by *pro* (Alexiadou & Anagnostopoulou 1998; Barbosa 2010; see Camacho 2013). We see no reason to treat Akan preverbal DPs as dislocated.

- ➢ Taken together, Akan lacks the NSL properties that can be tested for (null expletives), and every person has an overt subject prefix (Table 2). Together with the referential and binding properties in §3.2, this argues against the null-subject analysis, although several of these properties are not individually diagnostic (Camacho 2013, p. 61).

4. Akan Pronominal Continuum

We show that on the pronominal continuum: clitic < weak < strong, Akan possess pronouns belonging to the extremes, i.e., strong pronouns and pronominal clitics (subject and object).

4.1. Prosodic Dependency

- ➢ Akan strong pronouns (column 2 of Table 2) can be coordinated with DPs ((17)).

(17) **Kofi bo-o Yaw ne ɔno.**
K beat-PST Y CORD 3SG
'Kofi beat Yaw and him.'

- ✓ It is important to mention that, as observed in ((18) a and b), both subject and object clitics in Akan occur in coordinate DPs.
- ✓ However, they are restricted: subject clitic to first coordinate and object clitic to second coordinate, hence the ungrammaticality of ((18)c).
- ✓ This can be attributed to the diachronic source of the coordinator **ne**, as copular verb (Amfo, 2010).
- ✓ We argue that it retains the verbal ability to host the clitics.
- ✓ The object pronoun **no** is taken to be a clitic since it has to always be adjacent (immediately following) to the verbal host.

(18) a. **ɔ-ne Yaw…**
3SG-CORD Yaw
'He and Yaw…'

b. **Kofi bo-o Yaw ne no.**
K beat-PST Y CORD him
'Kofi beat Yaw and him.'

c. *Kofi bo-o no ne Yaw.
K beat-PST him CORD Yaw
'Kofi beat Yaw and him.'

- Also, only strong pronouns can occur in isolation. (e.g. as a fragment answer)
  - ✓ Pronominal clitics must be adjacent to a lexical host (the verb): it cannot appear in isolation[2]

(19)

Question					*Answer*
a. **Hwan$_1$**	**na**	**Kofi**	**bo-o**	**no$_1$?**	**b. Ɔno**
Who	FOC	K	beat-PST	3SG	'him!'
'Who did Kofi beat?'					**c. *no**

(20)

Question				*Answer*
a. Hwan$_1$	**na**	**ɔ$_1$-bo-o**	**Yaw?**	**b. Ɔno**
who	FOC	3SG-beat-PST	Y	'him!'
'Who beat Yaw?'				**c. *Ɔ**

4.2. Syntactic Distribution

- Akan strong pronouns appear in peripheral positions ((21)a and b), but not base-generated in canonical subject position ((21)c)
  - ✓ Unless licensed by quantification or predication via an identificational copular construction ((21)d).

(21)

a. **Ɔno de-ɛ ɔ-bo-o Yaw.**
he TOP 3SG-beat-PST Y
'As for him, he beat Yaw.' [Topic position — OK]

b. Ɔno na ɔ-bo-o Yaw.
3SG FOC 3SG-beat-PST Y
'HE beat Yaw.' [Focus position — OK]

c. ***Ɔno bo-o Yaw**.
3SG beat-PST Y
'He beat Yaw.' [canonical subject — ungrammatical]

d. **Ɔno ne dɔkota no**
3SG COP doctor DET
'HE is the doctor.' [identificational copular]

- Pronominal clitics cannot occur in peripheral positions (except when coordinated).

[2] Yip and Ahenkorah (2022, 2024) argue that the subject forms do not necessarily cliticize onto the verb and thus represent them without clitic notations citing the example in (i). We speculate, however, that **tae** 'often' might have been a been a (modal) verb in the language much like the coordinator **ne**. This is evidenced by its ability to be negated in (ii). In a personal conversation, Yip agreed with this speculation of ours.

(i) **Ɔ tumi/ tae tu ndwom**
3SG.AN can/ often sing song
'S/he can/often sing(s).'

(ii) **Ɔ=n-tae n-tu ndwom**
3SG.AN=NEG-often NEG-sing song
'S/he won't often sing.'

(22) a. ***Ɔ-deɛ ɔ-bo-o Yaw.**
3SG-TOP 3SG-beat-PST Y
'As for him, he beat Yaw.'

b. ***No na Yaw bo-o no.**
3SG FOC Yaw beat-PST 3SG
'Yaw beat HIM.'

C. **Ɔ-ne no na Yaw bo-o wɔn.**
3SG-CORD 3SG.OBJ FOC Yaw beat-PST 3PL
'Yaw beat THEM.'

- Only strong pronouns in Akan can be modified by adverbials such as *only*, *also* etc.

(23) a. **Ɔno nkoaa/nso**. **b. *no nkoaa/nso.** c. ***Ɔ nkoaa/nso.**
3SG only/also 3SG only/also 3SG only/also

Table 3: Summary: Properties of the Akan strong pronouns and pronominal clitics[3]

Property	**Strong (ɔno)**	**Clitic (ɔ-/no)**
Independent prosodic unit	✓	✗
Coordinated with DP*	✓	✗
Fragment answers	✓	✗
Peripheral (topic/focus)	✓	✗
Adverbial modification	✓	✗
Canonical Argument position	✗	✓
Obligatory in A'-extraction	✗	✓

5. On the Default Marker or Non-Agreeing RP approach to *ɛ-* in A-bar Constructions

- ✓ In ex-situ subject focus, the RP prefixed to the verb surfaces as either **ɔ-** or ***ɛ-*** ((24)). Dolphyne (1988) notes that this alternation is especially visible in contexts where the focus marker **na** assimilates with the RP to yield ***ne*** or ***nɛ***.
- ✓ The question is whether ***ɛ-*** is a distinct morpheme or simply a reduced allophone of the pronominal clitic under some phonological conditions.

(24) a. **Ama$_i$ na {*_$_i$ / ɛ$_i$- / ɔ$_i$-} pɛ sika no**
Ama FOC 3SG.IN 3SG.AN want money CD
'It is Ama who wants the money.'

- ✓ Yip & Ahenkorah (2023) propose that ***ɛ-*** is a non-agreeing resumptive pronoun syntactically derived via partial copy deletion[4].

[3] To the best of our knowledge, this is the first study to propose pronominal clitic status for the object pronoun in Akan. We do this based on the empirical evidence presented thus far that show identical morpho-syntactic characteristics between subject prefix and object pronouns.

- ✓ Korsah (2017) treats it as the spell-out of a φ-feature bundle that appears when full agreement with an animate subject is not achieved.

Our Alternative Account

- ✓ The realization of **ɛ-** is phonologically motivated rather than syntactically.
- ✓ Production experiment in Pfeil, et al. (2015) provides empirical evidence for our claim.
- ✓ **ɛ-** appears only where **na** has assimilated, absorbing the RP ((25)a), while fully realized **na** always surfaces with **ɔ-** ((25)c).
- ✓ The complementary distribution, **na** + (deletion of) **ɔ-** vs. **ne/nɛ**, follows phonological reduction, not morphosyntactic alternation.

(25)

a. **SARA nɛ kura apro no**.
Sara FCO.3SG hold apple DET
'SARAH is the one holding the apple.'

b. **ɛ-yɛ THOMAS nɛ kura aborɔbɛ no**.
3SG.INA Thomas FCO.3SG hold pineapple DET
'It is THOMAS who is holding the pineapple.'

c. **SARA na ɔ-kura apro no**.
Sara FCO 3SG- hold apple DET
'SARAH is the one holding the apple.'

- ✓ Consider also ((26)) which involves local extraction but with some time adjunct.
- ✓ When the focus marker **na** and the subject clitic **ɔ** occur side by side (not separated by the adverbial), **na** + **ɔ-** can optionally be reduced to **nɛ** in fast speech ((26) a and b).
- ✓ However, when the adverbial comes between the focus marker **na** and the RP **ɔ-**, phonological reduction cannot apply ((26)c). This gives credence to our alternative analysis.

(26)

a. **[$_{Adv}$ da biara], Kofi na (ɔ-nyane / ɛ-nyane) me.**
day every K FOC 3SG-wake / 3SG-wake 1SG
'It is Kofi who wakes me up every day.'

b. **Kofi na (ɔ-nyane / ɛ-nyane) me [$_{Adv}$ da biara].**
K FOC 3SG-wake / 3SG-wake 1SG day every
'It is Kofi who wakes me up every day.'

c. **Kofi na, [$_{Adv}$ da biara], (ɔ-nyane / *ɛ-nyane) me.**
K FOC day every 3SG-wake / 3SG-wake 1SG
'It is Kofi who wakes me up every day.'

- ✓ This phonological pattern is observed outside A-bar constructions. We observe it
- ✓ They appear to involve the interaction between /a/ and some elision.

(27) a. **/Kofi na ɔ-re-ba/** (UR)
[Kofi nɛɛ-ba] (SR)
K FOC 3SG-PROG-come
'It is Kofi who wakes me up every day.'

b. **/Kofi nso re-ba/**
[Kofi nsoo-ba]
K also 3SG-PROG-come
'Kofi is coming too.'

c. **/Kofi nkoa re-ba/**
[Kofi nkoɛɛ-ba]
K only 3SG-PROG-come
'Kofi is coming alone.'

(28) **a. Ama re-ba.** **Amɛɛ-ba.**
Ama PROG-come
'Ama is coming.'
b. Kofi re-ba. **Kofii-ba**
Kofi PROG-come
'Kofi is coming.'

- ✓ There appears to be a phonological process instantiated by the present of /a/.
- ✓ This explains the unavailability of embedded **ɛ-** subject and the problematic nature of ((29)) from Yip and Ahenkorah (2023).
- ✓ Korsah (2017) treats ((29)) as ungrammatical. See his syntactic account in §3.4.1.3 in dissertation.

(29) **Ama$_i$ na Kofi dwene-e [$_{CP}$ sɛ {*_$_i$ / ɛ$_i$- / ɔ$_i$-} pɛ sika no]** (long-distance)
Ama FOC Kofi think-PST COMP 3SG.IN 3SG.AN want money CD
'It is Ama who Kofi thought that she wants the money.' (gap, *ε*-)

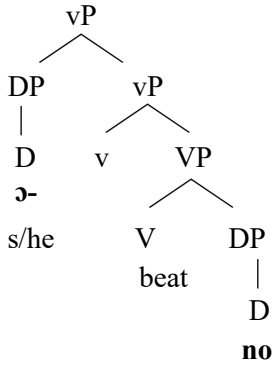
6. Proposed Analysis: Deriving Akan Subject and Object RPs

6.1 Non-A-bar contexts:

- ✓ Both subject and object pronominals are base-generated in canonical argument positions: Spec,vP and complement of V for pronominal subject and object clitics respectively as shown in figure ((30)b).

(30) a. **ɔ-bo-o no**
3SG-beat.PST him/her
'S/he beat him/her.'

b.



6.2 Subject/object RP in A-bar contexts:

- ✓ The DP undergoes movement (Chomsky 1995; Nunes 2004). Because Akan bans gaps in A-bar dependencies, the lower copy is spelled out as a pronoun matching the φ-features of the moved DP (Korsah & Murphy, 2024).

  - ✓ The DP undergoes A-bar movement (e.g., to Spec,FocP).
  - ✓ A resumptive pronoun is spelled out in the extraction site.
  - ✓ The pronoun matches the φ-features of the A-bar-moved DP.

(31)

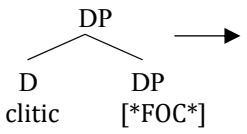
a. Base (After Subj. mvt.)	[$_{CP}$	C [$_{TP}$ DP	T[$_{vP}$ <DP> …]]
b. A-bar. mvt. (syntax)	[$_{CP}$ DP	C [$_{TP}$ <DP>	T[$_{vP}$ <DP> …]]
c. Pronoun Conversion (PF)	[$_{CP}$ **Kofi**	C [$_{TP}$ <DP >	T[$_{vP}$ <**ɔ**> …]]

  - ✓ The same applies to objects: an A-bar-moved object leaves a resumptive pronoun **nó** in its base position, complement matching the φ-features of the moved DP

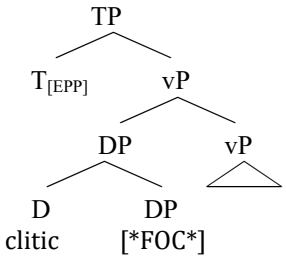
6.3 Alternative Big DP for A-bar RP

- ✓ Following Kramer (2014), a Big DP structure for subject RPs
- ✓ The entire DP moves to Spec,TP and the operator marked DP moves to criteria position, stranding the D-head which yields a bound verbal prefix through m-merger (Matushansky 2006).

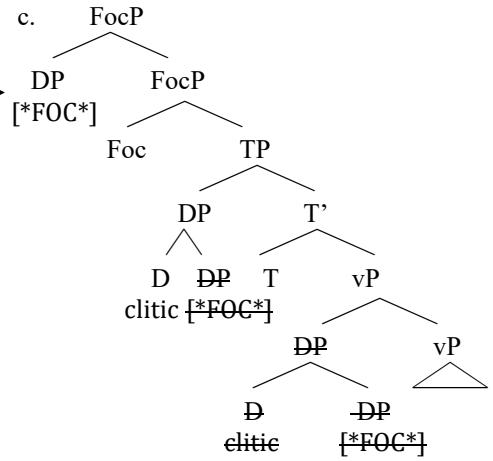
(32) a.



b.



c.



Takeaway

- ✓ Treating subject prefixes as agreement: full versus default, depending on some timing of movement between φP and DP introduces excessive theoretical complexity, which the RP analysis avoids.

7. Open questions

7.1 Base-Generation vs. Movement/Stranding Approach to RPs

Akan appears island-insensitive like Arabic (base-generation) but shows morphophonological reflexes of movement via high tone overwriting like Spanish/Igbo (movement-derived).

(adapted from Hewett, 2023).

	Island-sensitive?	License (local) PGs?	License stranding?	Case-marked operators?	Exemplar languages
Base-generated resumptives	No	No	No	No	Iraqi Arabic, Syrian Arabic, Tunisian Arabic, …
Movement-derived resumptives (and gaps)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Spanish, Swedish, Vata, Igbo, Romani, …

Evidence of movement?

There is evidence of movement (cf. Kobele & Torrence, 2006; Korsah & Murphy, 2020).

- ✓ Subject wh-words must front with **na**. They cannot stay in-situ suggesting the subject position must be evacuated via movement, ((33)).
- ✓ The optional **ɛ-yɛ** "it is" before the focused XP marks these as cleft constructions, which cross-linguistically involve movement to the left periphery, ((34)).
- ✓ Topics do not have tonal reflex. The RPs are base generated.

(33) a. ***hena bɔ-ɔ Ama**
who hit.PST Ama
'Who hit Ama?'

b. **hena na ɔ-bɔ-(ɛ-) Ama**
who Foc 3SG-hit.PST Ama
'Who hit Ama?'

(34) **ɛ-yɛ Thomas ne kura aborɔbɛ no.**
3SG.INA-COP Thomas FOC.3SG hold pineapple DET
'It is THOMAS who is holding the pineapple.'

7.2 The precise status of the 'default agreement marker' ɛ- in non-A-bar configurations.

Yip and Ahenkorah (2023): Akan subject movement from the edge of vP to the edge of TP

- ✓ Non-agreeing RPs: ✓, alternate with gaps
- ✓ Agreeing RPs: ✗, are banned

Korsah (2017): allomorphs of $T_{[\varphi:\ ]}$ ⟷ ***ɛ-/Ø***

(35) **Kofi (*ɔ-/ ɛ-)su-ui**[5]
K 3SG-/3-cry-PST

[5] Two colleagues who are also native speakers would not readily accept these sentences. They treat them as strongly marginal (??).

‘Kofi cried.’

(36) **M-mofra no$_i$ { _$_i$ / ɛ$_i$ } tu ndwom**
PL-child DET 3SG.IN- sing song
‘The children sing.’

Korsah (2017) also notes consistent tonal difference between ***ɛ-*** in clause-initial position and non-clause initial positions but says nothing more on this.

We do not have much to say either except that that ***ɛ-*** marker in Akan appears on several lexical items, and not just the verb.

Nouns:	**(*ɛ*-)dan**	‘house’
	(*ɛ*-)boɔ	‘stone’
Wh-words:	**(*ɛ*-)hen**	‘where’
	(*ɛ*-)deɛn	‘what’
Adverbial:	**(*ɛ*-)ha**	‘here’
	(*ɛ*-)hɔ	‘there’
Coordinator:	**(*ɛ*-)na**	‘and’
Focus:	**(*ɛ*-)na**	FOC

8. Conclusion

- ✓ Akan subject prefixes and object pronouns are pronominal clitics, not agreement markers.
- ✓ Akan has two classes of pronominals, strong pronouns and pronominal clitics, each with distinct prosodic, distributional and morphosyntactic properties. The clitic class comprises the subject prefixes and the object pronouns.
- ✓ The agreement account faces problems with referentiality and binding. A null-subject treatment is not supported either: the prefix is overt in every person and cannot co-occur with a subject DP.
- ✓ Subject and object pronominals receive one analysis: in A-bar contexts the DP moves and the lower copy is spelled out as a pronoun matching its φ-features.
- ✓ *ɛ-* is not a morphosyntactic variant of *ɔ-*, whether derived by partial copy deletion or by failed agreement. It results from phonological reduction when *na* is adjacent to the subject pronominal.

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